Fractal Shelter

Pitch Handbook

Creative Director, Producer - Leon Zhou

Lead Designer, Co-Producer - Steven Zhang

Lead Engineer, Co-Producer - Jeff Hu

01

Game Essence

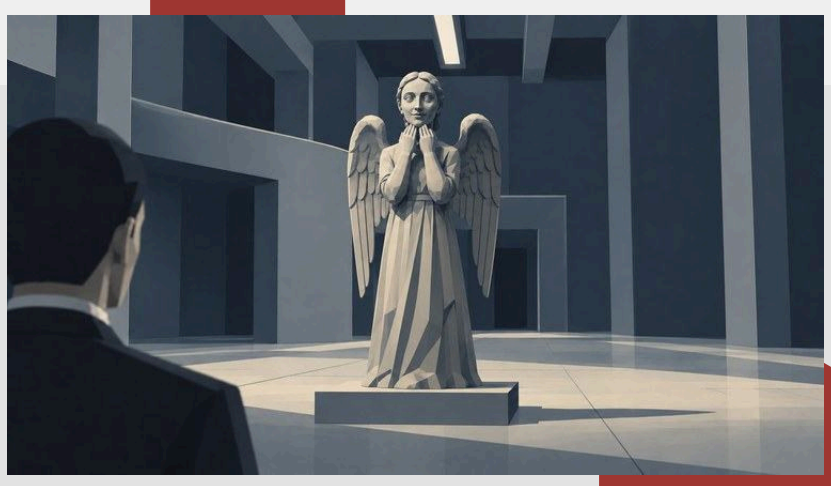


Fractal Shelter is a Metroidvania built around comic panels as the fundamental units of space.

You play as a comic-book character named **“Mr. Camera.”** When containment fails, an anomaly pulls you from the pages into reality, leaving you trapped inside the facility.

To find your way home, you must explore different anomalies and uncover the truth behind this world.

PAPER PROTOTYPE



FS-045 CRY ANGEL

NARRATIVE

The game is set in a New Weird world, drawing inspiration from SCP, Control, Triangle Agency, and Twin Peaks.

Civilization has collapsed. Deep underground, you awaken in the Fractal Shelter, a facility that has already fallen out of control. The space within the facility has fractured into comic-book panels that serve as the map. The shelter is overrun by **anomalies (FS-XXX)** that defy physics yet obey hidden rules.

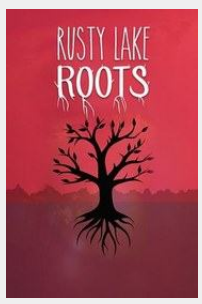
WHAT’S THE EXPERIENCE?

A Metroidvania played like manipulating a comic book.

Players freely explore a discrete, non-linear map of comic panels. By solving puzzles, navigating the space, and making choices, they gradually create the feeling of **“authoring the comic themselves.”**

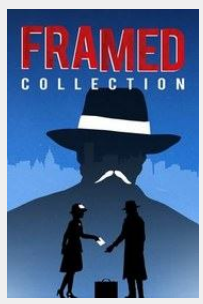
TARGET PLAYERS

- **Puzzle Game Fans**
- **Metroidvania Fans**
- **New Weird Lover**
- **Narrative Game Lover**



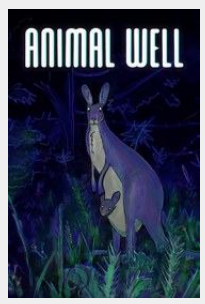
PUZZLE

+



COMIC PANELS

+



METROIDVANIA

=

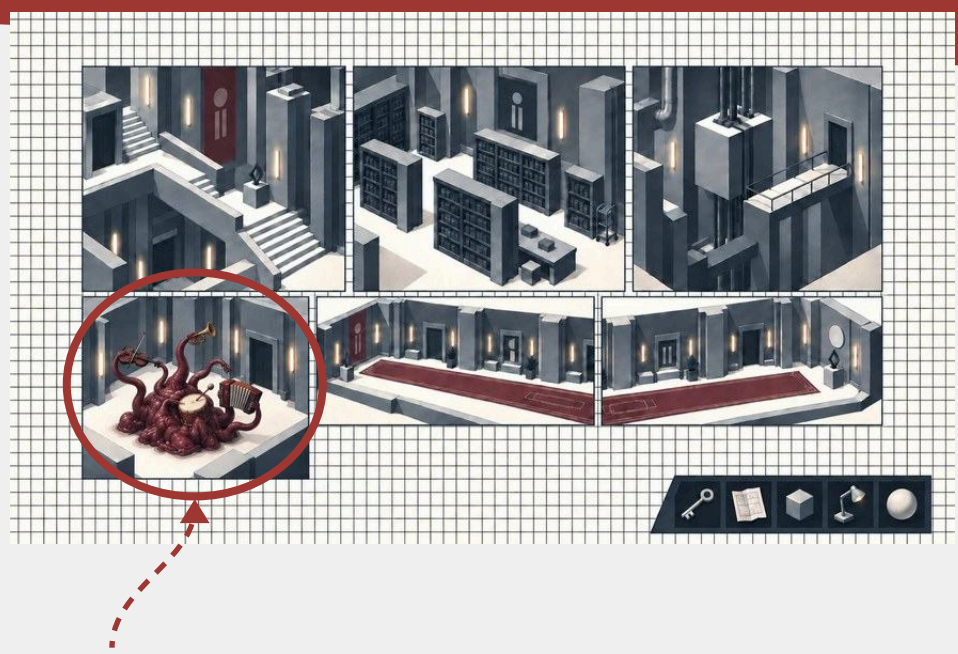
Imagine a New Weird game that combines the puzzle design of Rusty Lake, the comic-book presentation of FRAMED, and the nonlinear exploration of Animal Well.

02 Mechanics & Loop

HOW TO INTERACT

Players can drag items onto map panels to alter the state of the scene, and move between panels to reveal hidden puzzles.

Example: Drag FS-089 Sound Eater onto the panel containing **FS-072 Flesh Choir** to silence its song and neutralize its aggression.



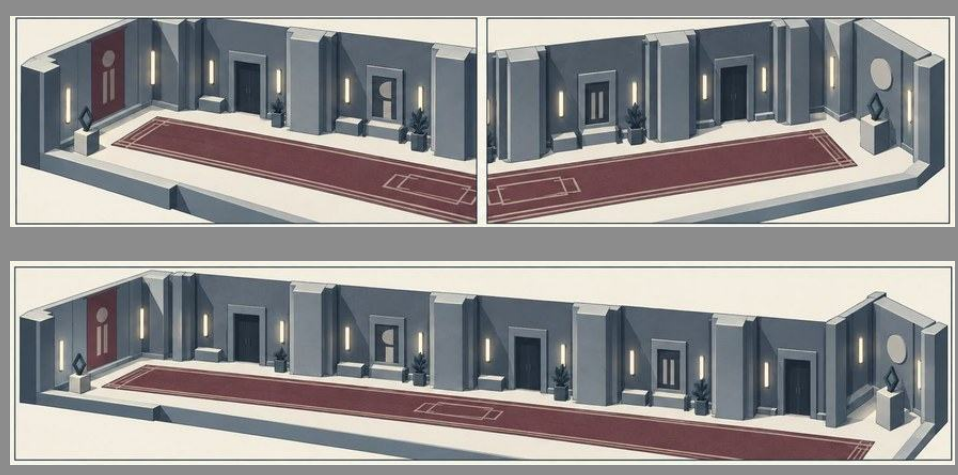


FS-089 Sound Eater
An anomalous device that absorbs all sound within a limited radius.

EXPLORATION

New areas discovered by the character are unlocked on a canvas in the form of panels.

Players are free to explore this **nonlinear Metroidvania** map, with multiple paths and no single prescribed solution.



CORE LOOP

01 Explore New Panels → 02 Discover Puzzles & Items → 03 Choose Items to Solve Puzzles → 04 Unlock New Panels

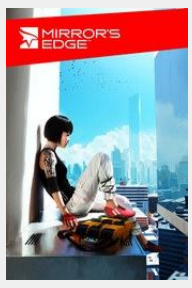
ART STYLE & TONE

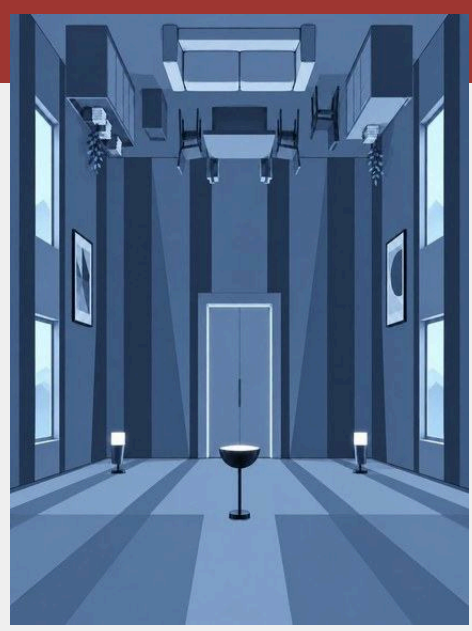
FLAT FUTURISM | MINIMALIST | INSTITUTIONAL | COLD

Stylized 3D-to-2D rendering that blends New Weird surrealism with clean, modern industrial design.









03 Team & Scope

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CREATIVES

1	**Creative Director**	
1	**Producer**	
6	**Designers**	2 Puzzle, 2 Level, 1 Technical, 1 Narrative
4	**Engineers**	1 Lead, 2 Gameplay, 1 UI
6	**Artists**	1 Lead, 2 Modeler, 1 Concept, 1 UI, 1 Technical
2	**UX & Accessibility**	
2	**Audio**	1 Composer, 1 SFX
2	**QA**	
1	**Marketing**	

Technology

MARKETING

Launch store pages early to build wishlists and grow an engaged **community** through devlogs, public playtests, festival demos, and creator outreach.

SCOPE & GOALS

90–120

MINUTES OF GAMEPLAY

3	40+	30+	2	3
MAIN AREAS	ITEMS	PUZZLES	DIFFERENT STORYLINES	DIFFERENT ENDINGS

Before enrolling at USC, I was already planning to form a team for the AGP project. Today, our team consists of three USC game enthusiasts.



Leon Zhou

DIRECTOR

I'm **Leon Zhou (Director)**, a first-year IMGD MS student, and my primary specialization is crafting and iterating on gameplay mechanics. I am a Gameplay Engineer with 1 year of experience, as well as a cross-border coordinator (Italy–China) and game jam leader, with hands-on skills in feature implementation, shaders, and editor tools.

ziangzho@usc.edu



Jeffery Hu

LEAD ENGINEER

Contributed to AAA projects at Tencent and NetEase Games. Led the release of two free games on Steam, reaching over 60,000 players.



Steven Zhang

LEAD DESIGNER

Led a five-person team through a six-month dev cycle to create a puzzle game, with proficiency in environment design, 3D modeling, and character rigging.

04 Timeline

Spring 2027 — N1



PRE-PRODUCTION

Build the Pre-Production Team
Framework of the game
Tune and Anchor Player Experience
Art exploration and research

Summer 2027 — N2



PRODUCTION

Build a Playable Prototype for Area 1
Finalize Settings and Stabilize Pipeline
Build and Grow the Community

Fall 2027 — N3

ALPHA

All Areas Finalized
All Major Mechanics Implemented
Alpha Test
Launch Store Pages
Launch the Official Website

Winter 2027 — N4

BETA

Refine and Balance Gameplay
Polish Art, Music, and Narrative Content
Complete Localization
Conduct Public Beta Testing

Spring 2028 — N5

FINAL RELEASE

Final Release
Push for Stretch Goals
USC Games Expo

